SkillNavora Academy · Chapter 4 of 19

Email Marketing and List Building

Study guide, workbook, troubleshooting and submission for a beginner

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CHAPTER 4 OF 19

Email Marketing and List Building

Build an owned email list, send your first campaign that does not land in spam, and measure the result. Written by Varun for SkillNavora.

Core learning objective

Build an owned email list with pop-ups and forms, and run campaigns through Mailchimp that are measured in Mailchimp and Google Analytics.

Four pillars

Pillar	What you do in this chapter
Understand	Why an owned list matters, and why Gmail is not a business email tool.
Implement	Create the account, add forms, write and send a campaign.
Optimise	Subject lines, timing, deliverability and reading the reports.
Apply	Inbox audit, the Chapter 4 assignment and the submission.

Tools

Tool	Use	Link
Mailchimp	Email service provider: lists, forms, campaigns, reports	mailchimp.com
Convertful	Pop-ups, sidebar forms and download forms for WordPress	convertful.com
WordPress	Your website (from Chapter 3)	wordpress.org
Google Analytics	Website and campaign measurement	analytics.google.com

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HOW THIS GUIDE WAS CHECKED

The live Mailchimp, Convertful, Gmail and Google Analytics pages could not be opened from the workspace used to write this. Plan limits, screens, benchmark figures and quoted remarks are marked for checking. Replace each with the official reading before you publish.

LECTURE 4.1 · UNDERSTAND

Why email is your most valuable owned channel

An email list is a list of people who gave you permission to contact them. You own it. Social feeds do not.

Pillars: Understand · Apply

1. Traffic on demand

Each time you publish a blog post or a video, you can tell your list. That gives you visits without buying ads.

2. Test ideas with your list

Send a short survey (Chapter 2) to your list. You learn what people will pay for before you build it.

3. Repeat sales

Past buyers are easier to sell to again. A message such as 'You bought X, this suits you too' is the basic idea behind many repeat-purchase emails.

4. Protection from platform changes

Social platforms can change what their feeds show, and they can suspend accounts. Your list stays with you, as long as you keep it legal and clean.

VERIFY FIRST

The course notes quote two marketers. Their remarks are opinions and anecdotes, not measured facts. Check the original source before you quote them, or do not quote them.

Practice

1. Write down three ways a list could help your business this year.
2. Name one platform you rely on that could change or ban you. How would you contact your audience if that happened?

Common mistakes

- Treating a social following as if you own it.
- Quoting a marketer without checking the source.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why is an email list 'owned'?
   Answer: You control it, unlike a social follower list on someone else's platform.
2. Why survey your list?
   Answer: To check demand before you build a product.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	I can list 3 reasons an email list helps.
☐	I can explain owned versus rented audiences.

LECTURE 4.2 · IMPLEMENT

Create your email service account

An email service provider (ESP) sends your emails to a list, tracks results and handles unsubscribes. Mailchimp is one option in the course.

Pillars: Implement · Optimise

1. Go to mailchimp.com and choose Sign Up Free.
2. Enter your email, a username and a password.
3. Click the activation link sent to your inbox.
4. Complete the human verification check.
5. Confirm which plan you chose. Read the current free-plan limits on the pricing page before you start.
6. Enter your name, business name and website address.
7. Add a physical postal address to your emails, as anti-spam laws such as CAN-SPAM require for commercial email in the US.

VERIFY FIRST

The course says the free classic tier supports up to 2,000 contacts. Plan limits change. Read the current number on Mailchimp's pricing page.

Address privacy

You do not need to show your home address. Options that many businesses use include a business address, a co-working desk, or a studio address. Check the current rule on Mailchimp's help pages.

Common mistakes

- Choosing a plan without reading its contact limit.
- Putting a home address in the footer without thinking about privacy.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why does an email need a physical address?
   Answer: Commercial email laws such as CAN-SPAM require one.
2. Where should you check current limits?
   Answer: The official pricing page.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Account created and activated.
☐	Plan limits checked on the official page.
☐	Physical address added.

LECTURE 4.3 · UNDERSTAND

Why not just use Gmail?

Gmail is fine for a few personal emails. It is not built for business email marketing.

Pillars: Understand

Need	Personal Gmail	Email service (ESP)
Sign-up forms on your site	No	Yes, with forms and pop-ups
Sending to many people	Gmail limits how many recipients you can send to	Built for large lists
Automatic welcome emails	No, manual only	Yes, automated sequences
Open and click reports	No	Yes

VERIFY FIRST

Gmail's recipient limits are set by Google and can change. Check the current Google help page for senders before you plan a large send.

Common mistakes

- Sending a newsletter from a personal Gmail inbox.
- Assuming Gmail will show you who opened your email.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What can an ESP do that Gmail cannot?
   Answer: Forms, automation and reports.
2. Is Gmail useless for business email?
   Answer: No. It is good for one-to-one mail. It is weak for newsletters.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	I can list the four gaps between Gmail and an ESP.

LECTURE 4.4 · IMPLEMENT

Add opt-in forms and pop-ups (Convertful and WordPress)

Opt-in forms collect email addresses. Place them where readers are most likely to join, not everywhere at once.

Pillars: Implement · Optimise

Five steps

1. Create a free Convertful account at convertful.com and verify your email.
2. In WordPress, go to Plugins, then Add New, search for Convertful, click Install Now, then Activate. Log in to link your account.
3. In Convertful, click Create Widget, then Popups, then Create Popup. Add your image, headline and button text.
4. Open the Display Rules tab. Choose Exit Intent or scroll past 20 percent of the page. Save, then set the widget to Active.
5. Open Integrations, add Mailchimp, and connect your account. Test your form in a private window.

Other placements

Placement	How it works
Sidebar form	Create an inline widget, copy its shortcode, then add it in Appearance, then Widgets, using a Text widget.
Download after a post (PDF)	Upload the PDF to your media library or cloud drive, paste its link into the download button, and set the display rule to after the post content.
Spin-to-win, welcome screen, content lock	Templates may exist in the tool. Use only if they suit your audience and do not trap visitors.

VERIFY FIRST

The course says to turn off double opt-in so people join in one step. Double opt-in gives proof of consent, which many consent rules expect. Turning it off can break consent rules where you live. Check local rules first.

WATCH OUT

Test every form in a private window. Confirm the new address appears in your audience list.

Common mistakes

- Showing a pop-up on every page the moment it loads.
- Skipping the test and finding out later that forms do not save.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What does Exit Intent mean?
   Answer: The pop-up shows when the visitor is about to leave.
2. Why test in a private window?
   Answer: It shows what a new visitor sees, not your logged-in view.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Opt-in form live.
☐	Test sign-up appears in the list.
☐	Consent setting chosen with the local rules in mind.

LECTURE 4.5 · APPLY

Write subject lines that get opened

The subject line decides whether your email is read. Study your own inbox before you guess.

Pillars: Apply · Understand

Inbox audit method

1. Open your promotions folder. Mark five emails you opened and five you ignored.
2. Write each subject line in a table, with a column for why you opened or ignored it.
3. Find two patterns that worked, such as a number or a question.
4. Write three subject lines for your own email, using those patterns.
5. Ask a teammate to do the same, and compare.

Patterns to test

Pattern	Example (format only)	Why it can work
Number plus topic	7 ideas for [your topic] this year	A number sets an expectation
Personal question	Are you still there, [First Name]?	It feels personal
Measured result	[Method] helped us cut [problem] by 30 percent	Only use a real, checked result
Seasonal goal	Set your [season] goal in 10 minutes	It fits what readers are doing now

Patterns that failed

Pattern	Why it fails
Vague: Let's talk	No reason to open
Urgency with no topic: Last call, 3 hours left	Reader does not know what is on offer
Buried offer: a long intro before the offer	The offer is cut off on screen

TIP

Put the number, the offer and the deadline at the start: 'Get 10 plugins for $19 each, 3 days left'. Check any price on the official page first.

VERIFY FIRST

The example subject lines in the course notes are real emails from other businesses. Do not copy them. Use the format only.

Common mistakes

- Using a subject line that cannot be true.
- Writing a subject line longer than the inbox shows.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. What is the first step of the audit?
   Answer: Open your promotions folder and mark what you opened and what you ignored.
2. Why put the offer first?
   Answer: Readers may only see the first words.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Audit table made.
☐	Three subject lines written.
☐	Teammate comparison done.

LECTURE 4.6 · IMPLEMENT

Create and send your first campaign

A campaign is one email sent to your audience. Follow these steps in order, and always send a test first.

Pillars: Implement · Apply

Five steps

1. In Mailchimp, go to Campaigns, then Create Campaign, then Email. Name the campaign and choose your audience list.
2. Set the From address to your own domain (for example, you@yourdomain.com). Verify it and click the link Mailchimp sends.
3. Enter your subject line and preview text. The preview text is the short line shown next to the subject.
4. Design the email with a clear headline, body text and one button. Click Send a Test Email to yourself and check the sender name, links and images.
5. Schedule the send for a time that suits your readers. Check the time zone shown on screen.

Why a custom domain sender?

- **Brand:** people see your name every time.
- **Trust:** a business address looks more professional than a free webmail address.
- **Delivery:** sending domains are checked with email authentication records (SPF and DKIM). Mailchimp's domain setup helps you add them. DMARC is a policy you set for your domain.

Scheduling across time zones

Place	Example time (when UK is 5:00 PM, in winter)
UK / Ireland	5:00 PM
San Francisco	9:00 AM
New York	12:00 PM
India	10:30 PM

VERIFY FIRST

The times above are for one example date. Daylight saving changes them. Check your audience's location on your own reports and choose a time that fits them.

WATCH OUT

Never send a campaign from a free webmail address. Verify the domain first.

Common mistakes

- Sending without a test email.
- Scheduling at a time that suits you but not your readers.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why send a test?
   Answer: To catch broken links, the wrong sender name, and cut-off subject lines.
2. Why use your own domain?
   Answer: Brand, trust and delivery.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	From address verified.
☐	Test email received and checked.
☐	Schedule chosen with the audience's time zone.

LECTURE 4.7 · OPTIMISE

Measure your email results

Read the numbers after 24 to 48 hours. Compare them with your own past sends first, and only then with an industry average.

Pillars: Optimise · Apply

1. Mailchimp report

1. Open the campaign report.
2. Check the open rate. It is less reliable than before, because some email apps load images and open emails automatically. Use it as a trend.
3. Check the click rate. This shows whether your button or link worked.
4. Check unsubscribes. A small number is normal. A sudden rise means the content or frequency needs changing.
5. Check the 24-hour performance chart. If opens peak an hour after sending, try scheduling an hour later next time.

VERIFY FIRST

The course notes give industry figures (for example 13.8 percent open rate and 5.6 percent click rate for education). These are examples from the notes. Check the benchmark source before you compare.

2. Google Analytics

1. Connect Mailchimp to Google Analytics using the setup in Mailchimp's integrations.
2. In Google Analytics 4, look under Reports, then Acquisition, then Traffic acquisition. Filter by the campaign name you used in the links.
3. Check new users, engagement time and goal conversions from that campaign.

VERIFY FIRST

The course path 'Acquisition, then Campaigns, then All Campaigns' is from older Google Analytics. Google Analytics 4 uses different menus. Check the current Google Analytics help for your property.

Common mistakes

- Judging a campaign after two hours.
- Comparing your results only with someone else's benchmark.

NEXT CHAPTER

Next: Chapter 5, Conversion Copywriting. Practise it here: Copywriting workshop.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK

1. Why check after 24 to 48 hours?
   Answer: Most opens happen in that window.
2. Why are open rates less reliable?
   Answer: Some email apps open messages automatically.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Campaign report read.
☐	Analytics filtered by campaign.
☐	One change chosen for the next send.

LECTURE 4.8 · APPLY

Chapter 4 assignment and official resources

Build your list, send one campaign, and measure it.

Pillars: Apply

Your assignment

1. Create and verify a Mailchimp account with your domain email.
2. Connect Convertful to your website. Launch an exit-intent pop-up, a sidebar form and a download form.
3. Send a test email, then a real campaign, and record the results after 24 to 48 hours.

Official resources

- Mailchimp Help Center
- Mailchimp Marketing Resources
- Gmail Help
- Google Analytics Help
- FTC: CAN-SPAM compliance guide

PLEASE CHECK FIRST

Email tools, free-plan limits, benchmark figures, screens and rules change often. The links in this chapter were not checked live from this workspace. Confirm each one on the official site before you rely on it. Figures from the course notes are examples, not guarantees.

Lecture completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Account created and domain verified.
☐	Opt-in forms live and tested.
☐	First campaign sent after a test.
☐	Results recorded after 24 to 48 hours.

WORKBOOK

Email planner and checklists

Printable worksheets. Fill in as you go.

A. Email list plan

Question	Your answer
Who will join?	
What free offer will you give?	
How often will you send?	

B. Campaign planner

Item	Plan	Done
Subject line		☐
Preview text		☐
Button text and link		☐
Test email sent		☐
Send time		☐

C. Results log

Date	Subject	Opens	Clicks	Unsubscribes

REFERENCE

Troubleshooting

Use this when a step does not work.

Problem	Check
Sender not verified	Open the verification email and click the link. Check the spam folder.
Form does not save	Test in a private window. Check the Mailchimp integration is connected.
Email lands in spam	Check domain authentication, your subject line, and that the list is opted in.
Broken link in the email	Click every link in the test email before you send.
Low clicks, good opens	Change the button text, and check the link is near the top.

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REFERENCE

Email glossary

Plain-English meaning and an example for each email term.

Term	Meaning and example
ESP	Email service provider: a tool that sends bulk email and reports results. Example: Mailchimp.
Opt-in	Someone agrees to receive your email. Example: a sign-up form.
Double opt-in	A second step to confirm the sign-up. Example: a confirmation link in an email.
Subject line	The headline people see first. Example: '3 invoice mistakes to fix'.
Preview text	The short line after the subject. Example: 'Fix them before month-end'.
Open rate	The share of recipients whose emails were opened (tracked, but less reliable now).
Click rate	The share of recipients who clicked a link.
Unsubscribe	A person removes themselves from the list. Example: the link in the footer.
Segment	A smaller group in your list. Example: people who bought a course.
Automation	Emails sent by a rule. Example: a welcome series.
SPF	A DNS record listing which servers may send mail for your domain.
DKIM	A signature on outgoing mail that the receiver can check.
DMARC	A policy that tells receivers what to do when SPF or DKIM fail. Example: quarantine or reject.
CAN-SPAM	A US law on commercial email, including a physical address and an unsubscribe.

FINISH

Submission template and rubric

Copy this page for your submission. Score yourself out of 100.

Field	Your answer	Points
Mailchimp account and verified domain sender		20
Three opt-in forms live and tested		20
Subject lines audit (table and three new lines)		15
Test email and first campaign sent		20
Results after 24 to 48 hours with one next step		25
Total		**100**